

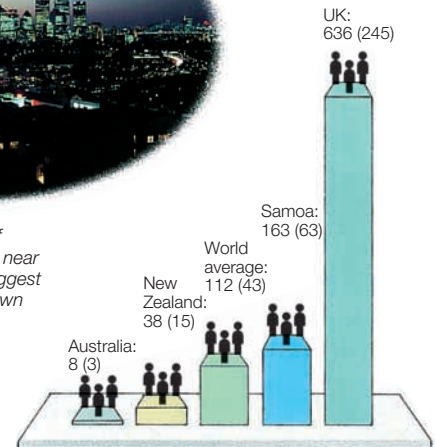
PEOPLES OF AUSTRALASIA AND OCEANIA

ISOLATED FROM THE REST OF THE WORLD, parts of this region were among the last places on Earth to be settled. The first inhabitants came from Asia, and include the Aboriginals of Australia, the Maoris of New Zealand, and the peoples of the Pacific Islands. In the 18th century, settlers started to arrive from Europe, and both Australia and New Zealand became British colonies. Many Pacific Islands were European colonies. Today, links with the European colonizers are no longer so strong. In recent decades, people have migrated to Australia and New Zealand from the Middle East and Southeast Asia, and both countries now have multicultural societies and successful modern economies.

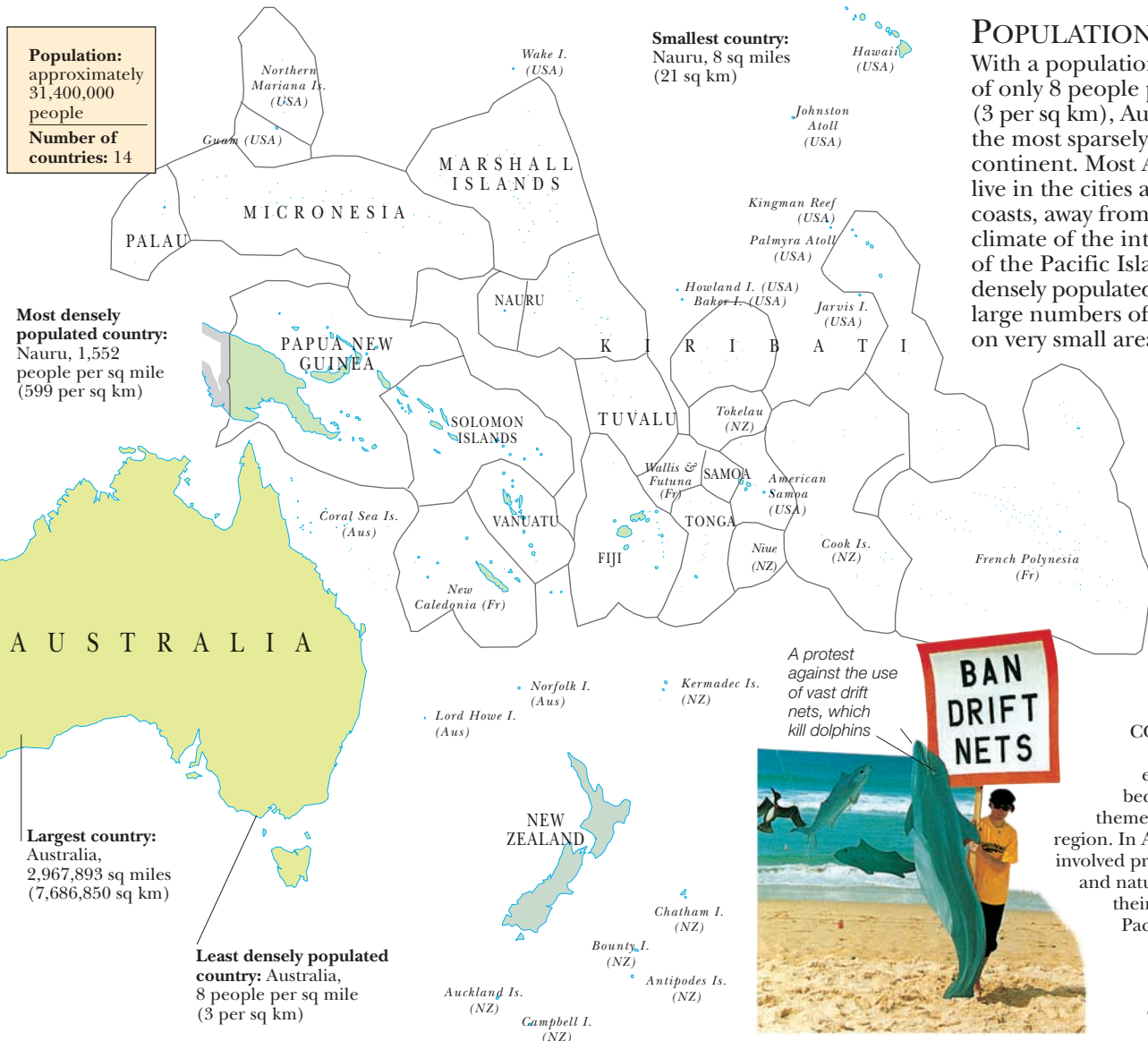


About 60 percent of Australians live in or near the country's five biggest cities – Sydney (shown here), Melbourne, Brisbane, Perth, and Adelaide.

Population density chart



The figures show the number of people per sq mile, with per sq km in brackets.



POPULATION DENSITY

With a population density of only 8 people per sq mile (3 per sq km), Australia is the most sparsely populated continent. Most Australians live in the cities around the coasts, away from the harsh climate of the interior. Many of the Pacific Islands are more densely populated, as relatively large numbers of people live on very small areas of land.

A protest against the use of vast drift nets, which kill dolphins



CONSERVATION

Concern for the environment has become a common theme throughout the region. In Australia this has involved protecting wildlife and natural sites. Due to their isolation, some Pacific Islands have been used for nuclear testing despite strong opposition from local people.